

governmental or other bodies to pressure those who have legal control over the technical infrastructure to comply with requests to block, filter or collect information. Many parts of the international infrastructure that supports the Internet are under the control of governments or government-controlled agencies, and they may easily assert control, in accordance with local law or not. Sounds scary, doesn't it?

Filtering or blocking parts of the Internet may be done in a subtle fashion without any prior notice to users or it may be in the form of clearly defined public agenda, but it almost always invites criticism. Various countries openly block various parts of the Internet as part of a well-established policy (like China), and restrict access to websites with takedown notices for people to read (like the FBI did in the case of Megaupload.com). What is deplorable, though, is when nation states either collude with or force ISPs to filter content disguised as technical failures without taking any responsibility for their actions. That's certainly damaging for everyone who's in favour of an open, free and fair global Internet.

Take back control

As the American computer innovator John Gilmore noted in a TIME magazine article, way back in 1993, "The Net interprets censorship as damage and routes around it." Prophetic words indeed, ones that still ring true. As long as you are absolutely certain to tear down imaginary digital walls that prevent you from accessing whatever it is that you want to access, know that the setback is only temporary and all's not lost. Despite censorship, content filtering, and other Internet restrictions, there are ways to circumvent roadblocks to get what you want. However, by doing this, only you can accurately ascertain the risk vs reward tradeoff in your actions. While there may not be specific laws preventing you from accessing perfectly legal, freely available content on the Web, spreading it may increase the odds of further inviting trouble – harassment of some kind, job termination, cyber bullying, incarceration, or worse. Having said that, remember that staying truly anonymous online isn't easy. Plenty of so-called full-proof, encrypted software abound on the Web, but who can

FROM THE NSA FILES

As far as mass surveillance programs go, the NSA's PRISM is pretty much the gold standard in the world, based on publicly available information. If the NSA has trouble breaking into any encrypted system (or communication), it can be safely assumed that your secrets are safe from almost any other crypto-analytic mechanism of the world as well. But the NSA has so much data to analyze and break down, how does it grade all that data going out into the world and funneling into their systems? And on occasions when it happens, how does it ascertain that it has finally met its match?

According to freshly leaked NSA documents, the NSA grades their target from a scale of one to five, or trivial to catastrophic, where one is the easiest target to break while five is almost impossible to break (never say never, right?). For instance, breaking into a Level 1 target requires little or no effort because of the "trivial" nature of decryption techniques. Looking into someone's Facebook message, according to the leaked NSA documents, is a "minor" Level 2 decryption task. If you're connecting to the Internet and surfing the Web through just the Tor browser alone to avoid detection, monitoring your activities is a Level 4 "major" undertaking. Difficult to crack, sure, but not impossible. No sir. Catastrophic it surely isn't.



accurately tell which ones are monitored by the powers that be? Tread with caution.

1) Covering the basics

You're gung-ho about covering your tracks online but don't want to go to great lengths to arouse unwanted suspicion. All you're worried about is to circumvent online blockades that prevent you from accessing websites that you can't live without or you want online entities to just respect your privacy and not snoop around your digital tracks. For all you casual privacy enthusiasts, here are some standard steps you should take to take back control of your online activities.

- **Proxies:** Whether at work or in school, to bypass censorship blocks, you can merely visit <https://www.browseatwork.com> and enter your page request, and voila!, you'll notice how this simple but effective tool will deliver on most of your requests. You can install its browser plugin to securely and anonymously access content off any website. You can also visit <https://www.proxym.com/proxy> or Google "free proxies" and see which one works for you best.

- **Browser plugins:** It's funny how the Web operates, and also how online censorship agents don't understand how to block efficiently. If less-diligent blocking mechanisms only take out HTTP access to a web server, there's an outside chance that you can still access it through an encrypted HTTPS connection. To that effect, install the HTTPS Everywhere (<https://www.eff.org/https-everywhere>) extension jointly developed by the Electronic Frontier Foundation and The Tor Project. Through this browser extension – supported on all major browsers – your incoming/outgoing web connection is encrypted end to end. It also gives you a basic bypass against ill-implemented censor blocks.
- **Change DNS:** This is not so much for anonymizing your presence but for speedy, reliable access to online information. In case your ISP's primary DNS setting is malfunctioning (hint: website requests timed out, too many page not found errors, and just generally slower than usual connection) or if your office Internet connection has